

STAGE THREE • JOB APPLICATION & INTERVIEW SKILLS

FIRSTS

GROUP VERSIONS OF KEY EXERCISES

Live, group-adapted versions of the FIRSTS that benefit most from interaction

A Citrus Edition Facilitator Resource • Companion to the FIRSTS Manual

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FIRSTS • Group Versions of Key Exercises

Stage Three • Job Application & Interview Skills

PURPOSE

Interviewing is fundamentally a live, social skill — the single least useful way to practice it is entirely alone, in your head, with no real audience or feedback. Stage Three's Templates workbook is written for solo strategy and drafting, but a strong plurality of its FIRSTS genuinely need to be heard, challenged, or performed in front of another person before they're actually interview-ready.

This document adapts eight FIRSTS across Stage Three into pair, small-group, or full-panel formats. As with every stage, these are additions, not replacements — participants complete their own individual prep first, and the group version tests it under something closer to real conditions.

Each entry includes a suggested format, the extra time it adds beyond the solo version, numbered steps you can read almost verbatim to a group, and a short note on why the live version specifically matters here.

The Eight Adapted Exercises

FIRST C02

Application Strategy — Strategy Swap

TIME: +15 min beyond solo drafting

1. After drafting individually, pairs exchange strategies (target roles, target companies, weekly application volume).
2. Each partner asks one genuinely challenging question about the other's strategy: is this volume realistic? Is this target list too narrow or too broad?
3. Each person revises one element of their strategy based on the challenge.

FACILITATOR NOTE

An outside challenge, asked in good faith, often reveals an unrealistic assumption (volume too low, targets too narrow) that's invisible when planning alone.

FIRST C05

Job Listing Analysis — Group Decode

TIME: +15 min beyond solo work

1. Small groups of 3–4 each analyze the same real job listing (facilitator-provided or projected).
2. Each group has 5 minutes to identify the listing's genuine must-haves versus nice-to-haves, and any red flags.
3. Compare across groups: did everyone converge on the same must-haves, or did groups disagree?

FACILITATOR NOTE

Disagreement across groups is itself the lesson — job listings are often genuinely ambiguous, and this shows participants they're not alone in finding them hard to parse.

FIRST C06

STAR Answer Prep — Round-Robin Storytelling

TIME: +20 min beyond solo drafting

1. Groups of 3–4. Each person tells one STAR story aloud, in full, without reading directly from their written notes.
2. After each story, the group identifies out loud: was the Situation/Task genuinely concise, or did it take too long to get to the Action and Result?
3. Speaker gets one chance to retell a tightened version on the spot.

FACILITATOR NOTE

The single most common STAR weakness is an overlong setup that eats the time budget before the actual Result lands. Hearing it out loud, with real-time feedback, fixes this faster than any amount of solo rewriting.

FIRST C07

Behavioral Interview Prep — Rapid-Fire Practice

TIME: +15 min beyond solo prep

1. Pairs. Partner A asks Partner B three behavioral questions from a shared prepared list, one after another, no more than 90 seconds per answer.
2. Partner A gives one piece of feedback after all three: was there a consistent theme or strength coming through across all the answers?
3. Swap roles.

FACILITATOR NOTE

Answering multiple behavioral questions back-to-back under mild time pressure is much closer to a real interview's actual rhythm than untimed solo drafting.

FIRST C10

Mock Interview — Full Panel Simulation

TIME: +30 min beyond paired practice

1. Select one volunteer to be interviewed by a panel of 2–3 other participants in front of the full group.
2. Panelists ask a mix of prepared and improvised follow-up questions for 8–10 minutes.
3. Full group debrief: what specifically made the candidate's strongest answer strong? What would they genuinely want to hear more of?

FACILITATOR NOTE

A panel format with genuine follow-up questions is closer to a real interview loop than a single interviewer, and watching it as a full group multiplies the learning beyond just the volunteer.

FIRST C11

Job Offer Negotiation Prep — Negotiation Role-Play

TIME: +20 min beyond solo prep

1. Pairs. One person plays the candidate, the other plays a hiring manager delivering an initial offer that's genuinely a bit below the candidate's stated target.
2. Candidate practices their prepared counter-offer language out loud in real time.
3. "Hiring manager" gives honest feedback: did the counter sound confident, or apologetic?

FACILITATOR NOTE

Negotiation language that reads confidently on paper often comes out apologetic when actually spoken for the first time. This catches that gap before a real negotiation does.

FIRST C14

Mock Presentation — Small-Audience Delivery

TIME: +20 min beyond solo prep

1. Groups of 3-4. Each person delivers their prepared presentation excerpt (2-3 minutes) to the small group instead of alone in a mirror.
2. Audience gives exactly two pieces of feedback: one moment of genuine clarity, one moment that needs more explanation.
3. Optional second delivery incorporating the feedback, if time allows.

FACILITATOR NOTE

A live, if small, audience surfaces pacing and clarity issues that solo rehearsal never reveals, since a real audience's confused expression is instant, honest feedback.

FIRST C20

Offer Comparison Matrix — Outside Perspective Check

TIME: +15 min beyond solo matrix-building

1. Pairs (ideally people not evaluating the same offers). Each shares their comparison matrix and their current leaning.
2. Partner asks: "What matters to you that isn't actually on this matrix?" and "Is there a factor here you're overweighting?"
3. Each person adds or reweights at least one factor based on the conversation.

FACILITATOR NOTE

A matrix built entirely alone often quietly overweights the most emotionally salient factor (usually salary or prestige) at the expense of something genuinely important like growth trajectory or team fit. An outside question surfaces that.